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SPECIAL SERIES - Pitching Tips for Small Fry

Koosman Explains How Curves Hurt Arms of Kids Under 16

EDITOR'S NOTE: Jerry Koosman, 26, missed one month of the 1969 season yet turned in a 17-9 record while completing 16 of 32 starts. In the World Series against the Baltimore Orioles he won the second and fifth games and was one of the Met heroes involved in the first world championship for an expansion team.

By JERRY KOOSMAN  
Of the New York Mets  
Written for AP Newsfeatures

The legs are so important to a pitcher that we believe they are responsible for 75 percent of a pitcher's durability or stamina.

The legs do so much of the work while you are pitching that if your legs get weak your pitching will suffer. The arm can't do it alone.

You can hurt your arm very easily by pitching when your legs are weak or tired. Strong legs make for strong arms and that's why we start out in spring training by doing plenty of running. And us pitchers run all through the season.

I've had many youngsters ask me at what age they should try to throw a curve ball. I've talked to different doctors to find out their thinking on this.

They told me about the bone in the elbow of a pitching arm. That bone doesn't mature or get strong enough for curve balls until a boy is about 16 years old.

If you try to throw a curve ball before 16, your elbow bone is tender and you chip your elbow. We call that a Little League elbow.

This bone chip just lays in there and never grows back on and will just keep irritating the tendons and muscles in your elbow and you will have trouble for the rest of your life.

People say I have a fine follow through. It takes a lot of work and coaching. I owe that to a couple of fellows named Andy and Sid Cohen. They gave me much professional coaching when I was in the service at El Paso, Tex. They were coaching the San Francisco Giant farm club there.

Of course, when they coached me I was a free agent. I don't want people to think that Giant men are coaching Met pitchers. I didn't beat the Giants last year but as a 1968 rookie my record against them was 3 and 1.

I wanted so badly to make the major leagues that just before I went to spring training with the Mets in 1968 I pitched to my brother in a hay loft back home in Appleton, Minn. I wanted to make sure my arm would be in shape.

It was wintertime and with all the snow we have in Minnesota you can't throw outside. I thought I'd take advantage of the big hayloft my father had on his farm. It's a big barn. It gave me a chance to train out of the wind and the cold. My brother and I played catch back and forth. It sure has paid off.



Al's Second

USAC Stocks at Summit Pt.

JERRY KOOSMAN  
coached by Giants

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